

Why Nonprofits Want AI but Can't Use It

Organizing Data

Use: 19%
Want: 60%
Gap: 41 pts

Predictive AI

Use: 11%
Want: 52%
Gap: 41 pts

Virtual Assistant

Use: 16%
Want: 56%
Gap: 40 pts

Interpreting Data

Use: 15%
Want: 50%
Gap: 35 pts

Translate/Transcribe

Use: 24%
Want: 39%
Gap: 15 pts

Chatbot Q&A

Use: 33%
Want: 39%
Gap: 7 pts

Other AI Use

Use: 9%
Want: 12%
Gap: 3 pts

Generative AI

Use: 54%
Want: 55%
Gap: 1 pts

A data infrastructure story from 930 nonprofit survey responses worldwide

Nonprofits do not need more AI hype, they need better data plumbing

60%

Want AI help organizing data

19%

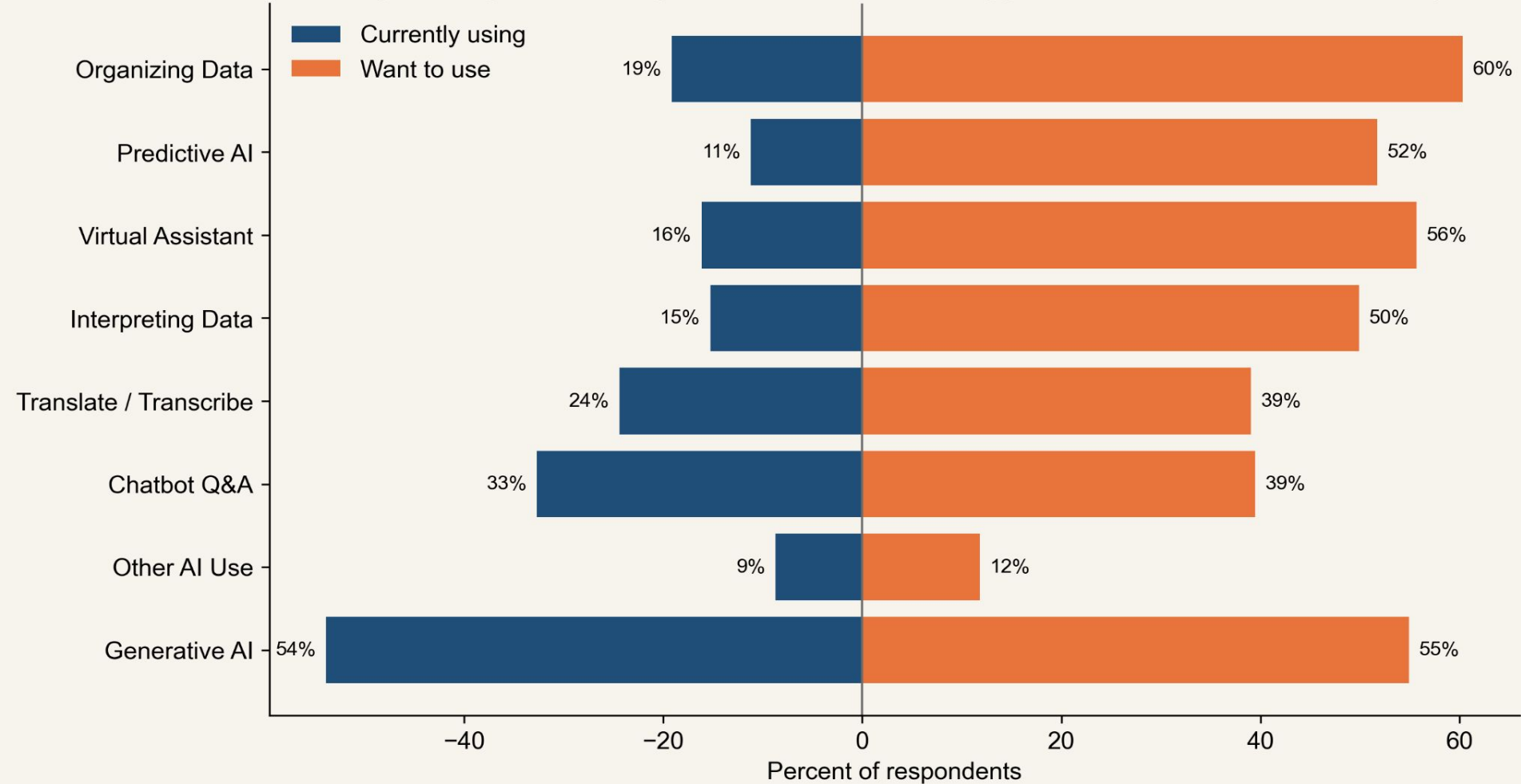
Already use AI for that

22%

Foundation-needed segment

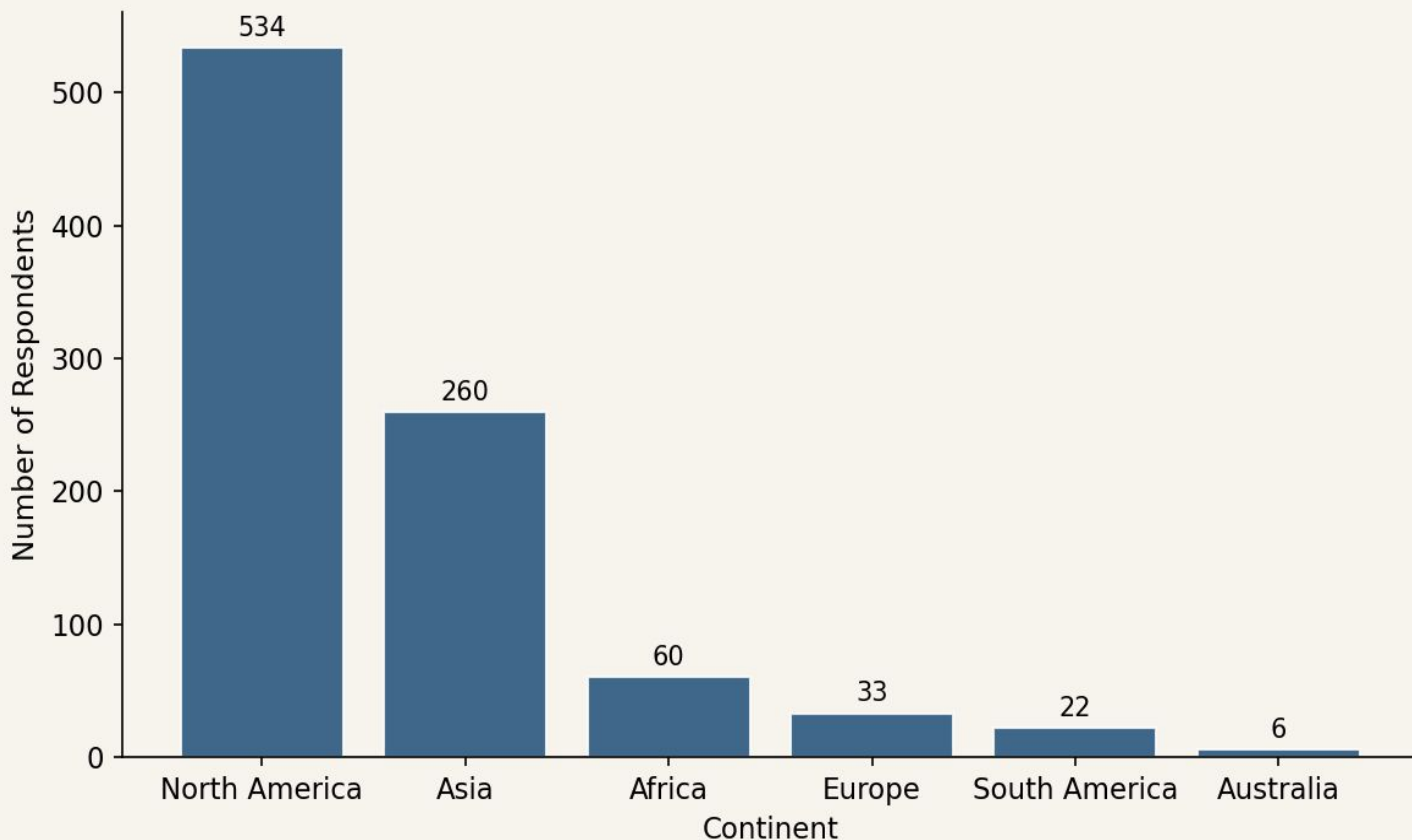
- Organizing data has the biggest unmet need in the whole survey, with a 41-point want-use gap.
- 36.99% of respondents want at least three more AI use cases than they currently use.
- 209 nonprofits fall into the Foundation-needed segment, meaning demand is real but the basics are not ready yet.

Organizing data, not generative AI, is the biggest unmet need in the survey



The sample is global, but it is still a small-org dataset with North America and India doing most of the talking

North America Dominates the Sample (n=930)



63%

15% staff or fewer

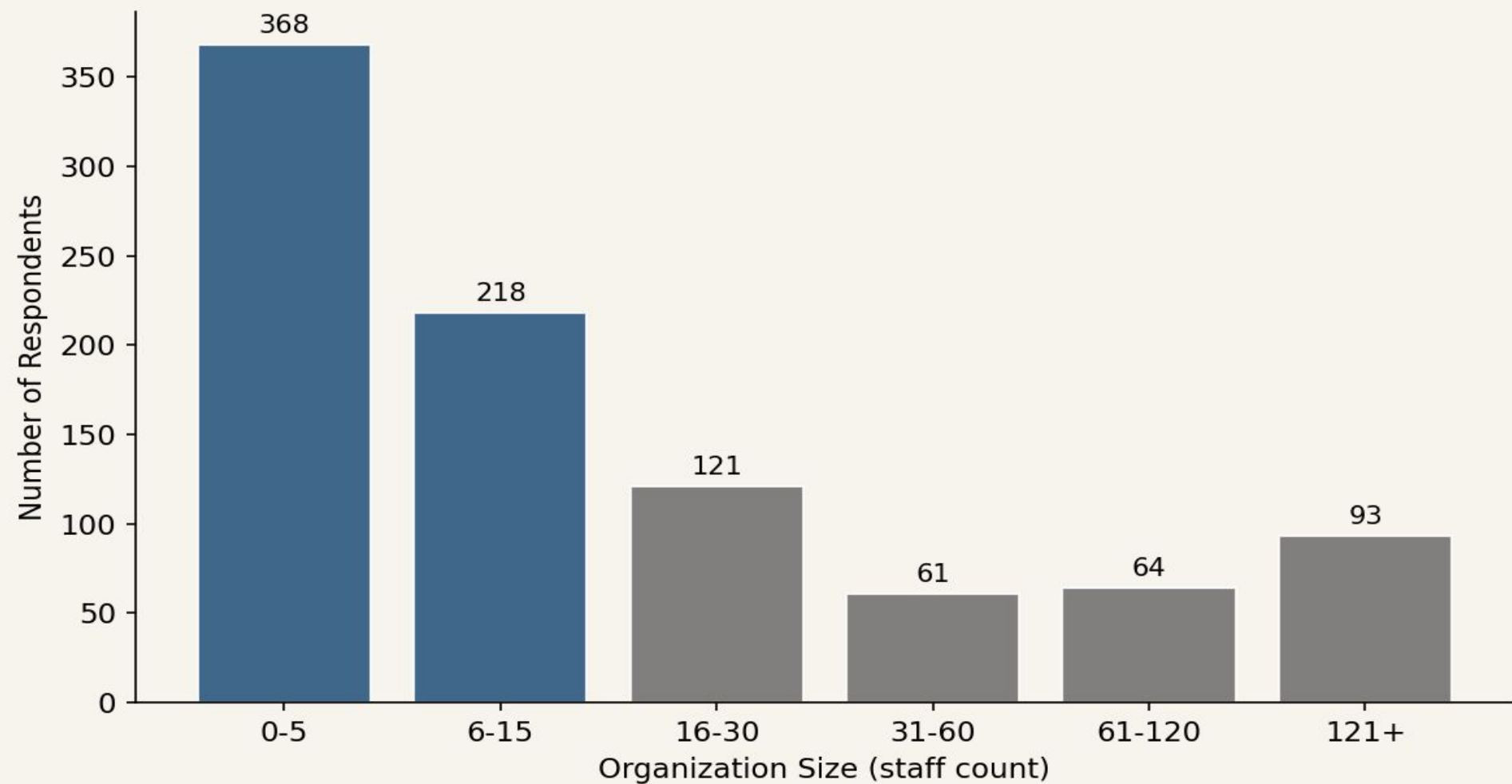
62.6%

Global North

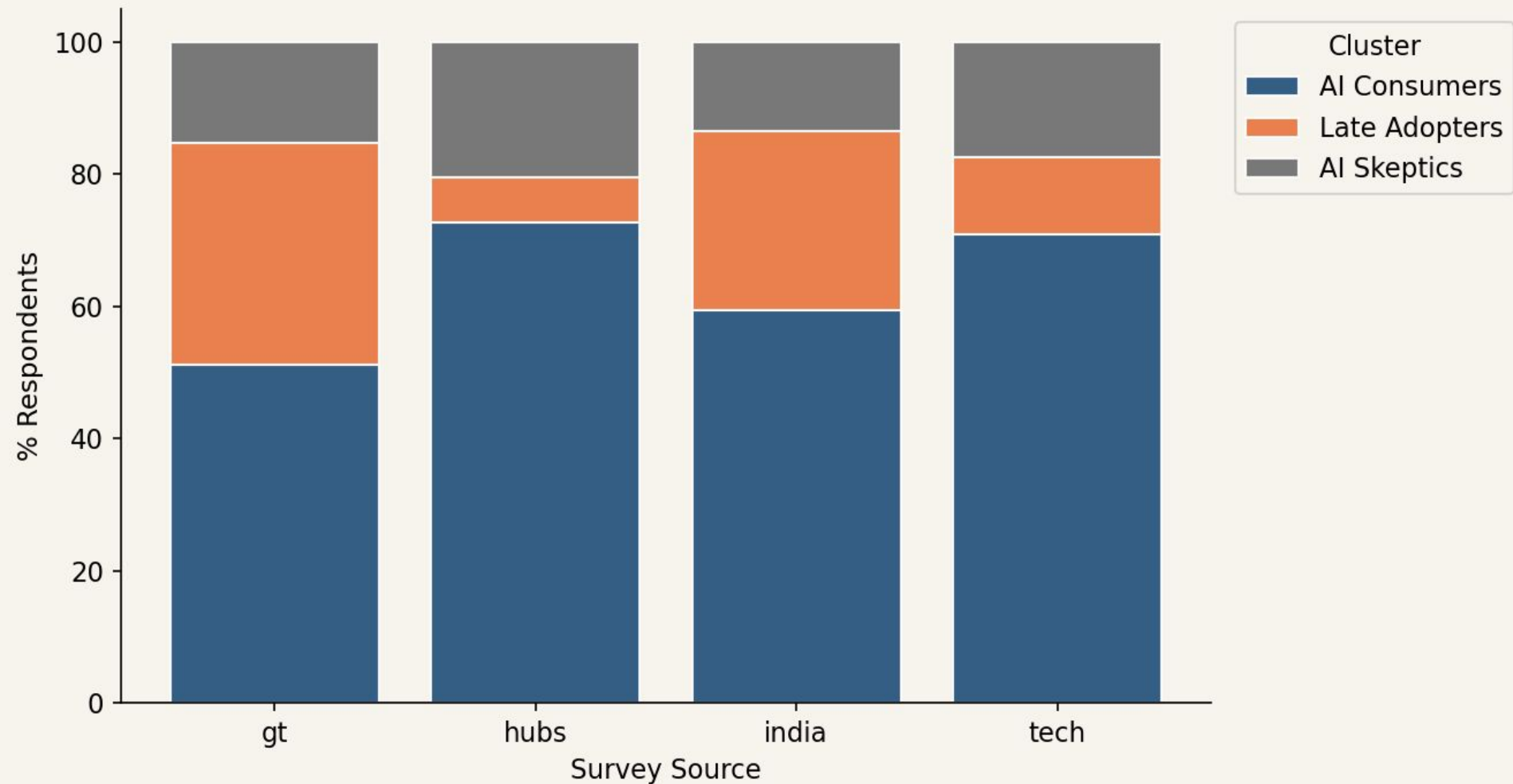
56%

AI Consumers

63% of Nonprofits Have 15 or Fewer Staff



India Cohort Has Highest AI Consumer Share



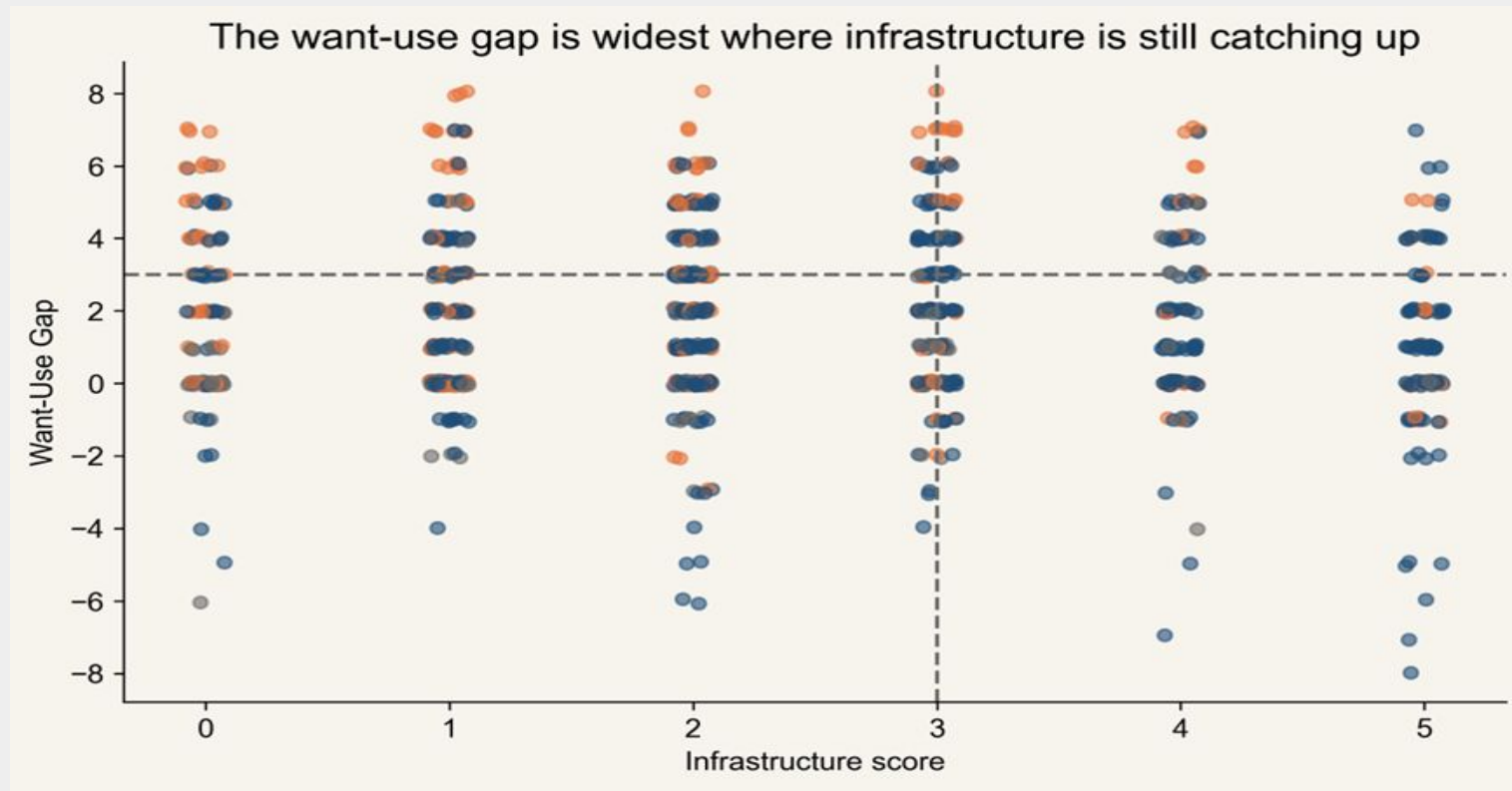
What the official report already established

- AI Consumers are the largest cluster (56%), Late Adopters are next (28%), and Skeptics are smallest (15%).
- Organizational capacity is a weak readiness proxy.
- Those with technical backgrounds tend to be more wary of AI risks.
- The biggest unmet AI need is help organizing data.

Where this deck adds something new

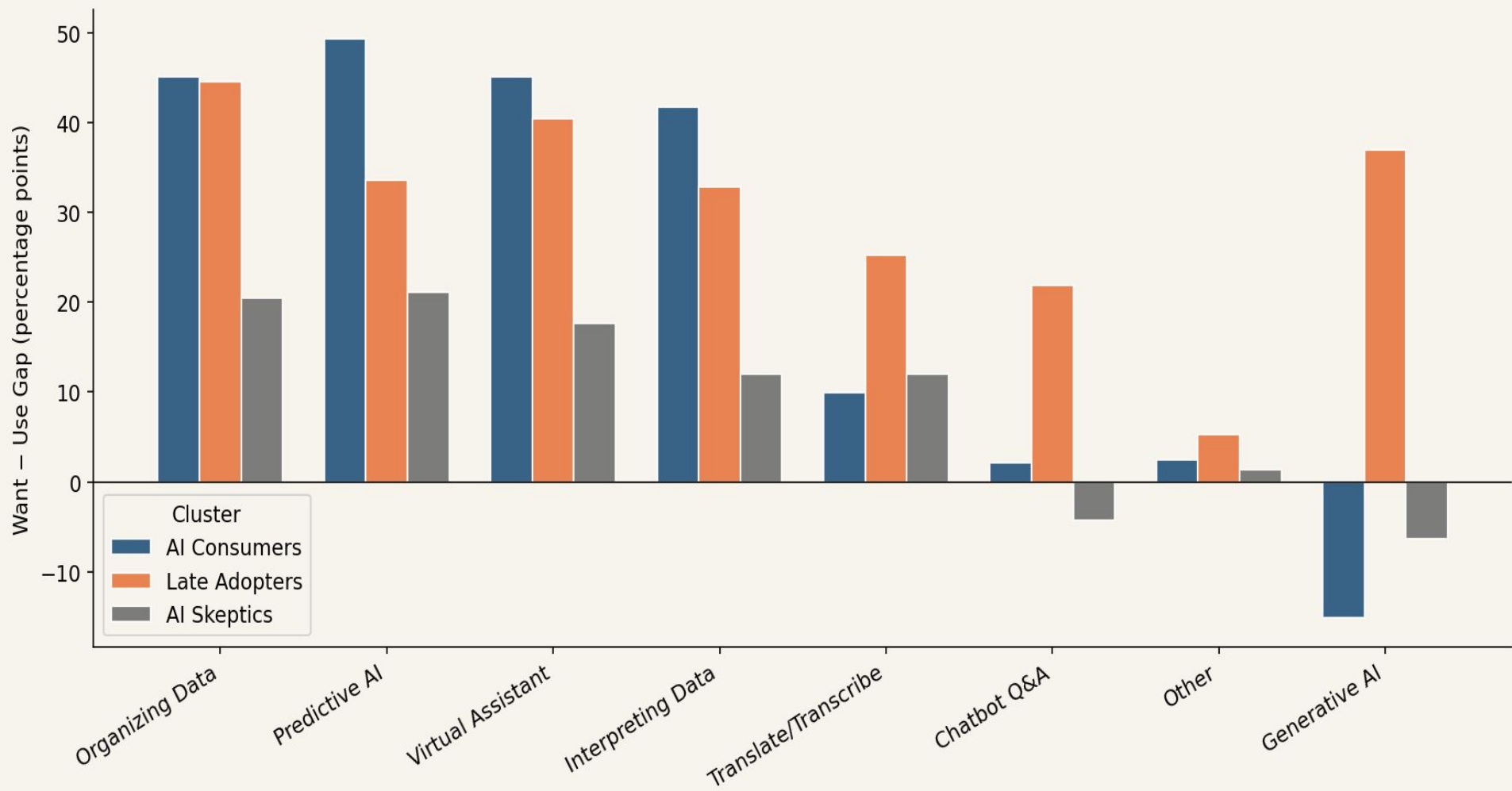
- It turns the want-use gap into a funder-ready segmentation.
- It shows India and Africa are not interchangeable inside the Global South story.
- It challenges the tidy 15-staff threshold by showing the steepest staffing jump happens earlier.
- It uses open text to show hope and fear living side by side.

Late Adopters have the biggest Want-Use Gap, which makes them the most important intervention group

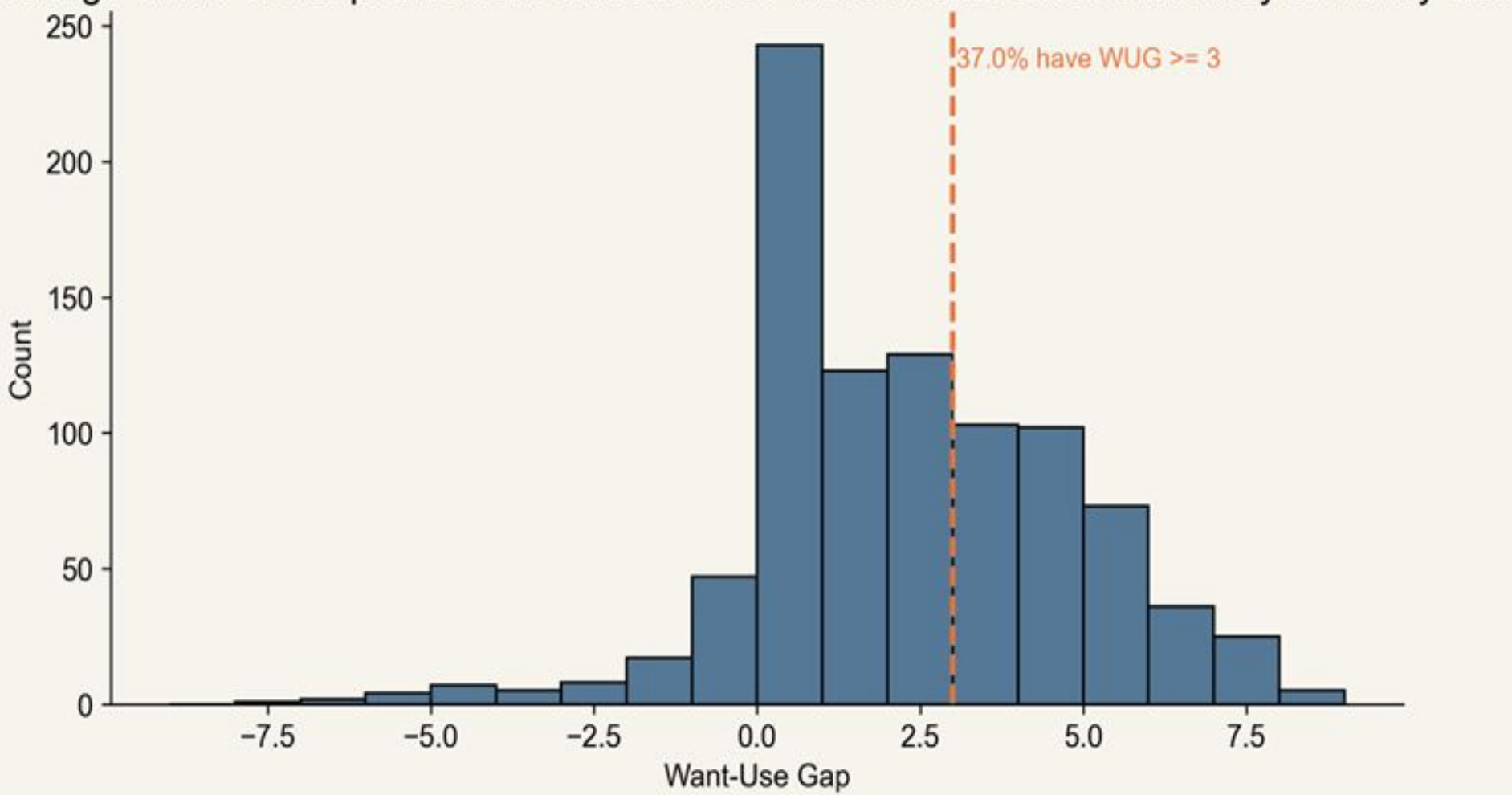


Late Adopters average a 2.41-point gap, versus 1.81 for Consumers and 0.74 for Skeptics.

Late Adopters Show Largest Aspiration Gaps Across Most Use-Cases



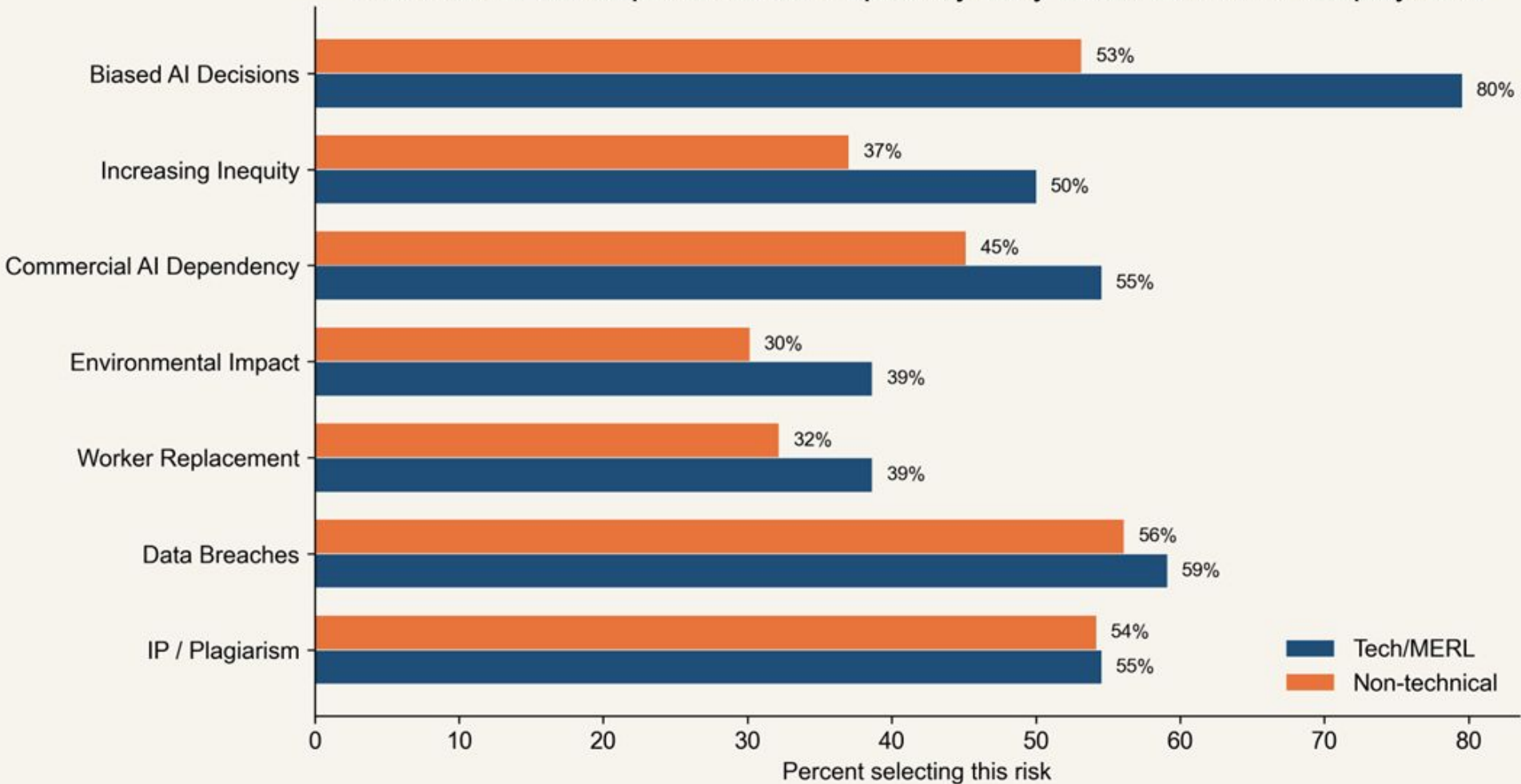
A large share of nonprofits want at least three more AI use cases than they currently use



Technical respondents are not calmer about AI, they are much more likely to worry about bias

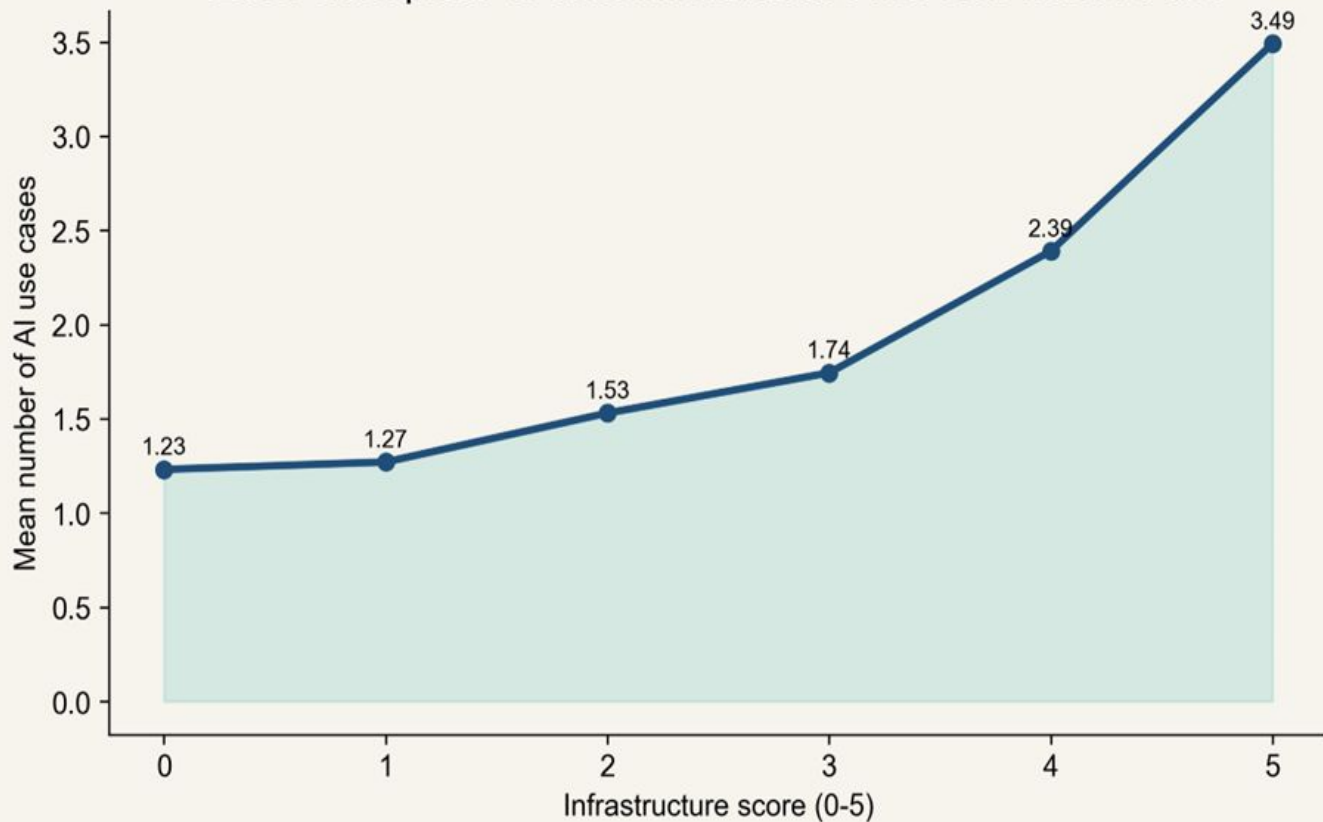
- 79.5% of Tech/MERL respondents flagged biased AI decisions, versus 53.2% of non-technical peers.
- That was the only risk difference that stayed significant after Holm correction (adjusted $p = 0.007$).
- This pushes against the idea that more technical literacy simply reduces fear.

Tech and MERL respondents are especially wary of biased AI and inequity risks



Each extra piece of data infrastructure lifts real-world AI use, even before we get fancy about modeling

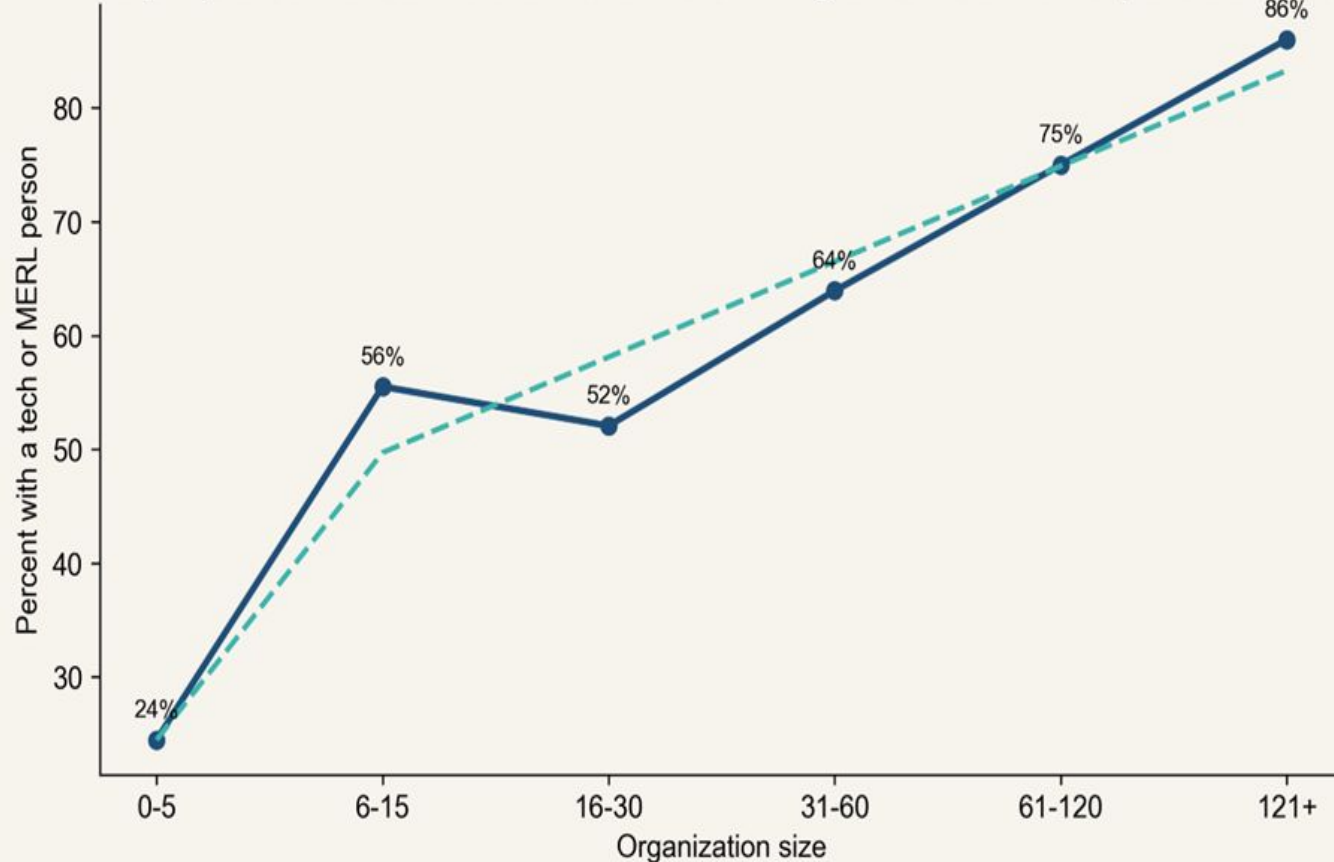
Each extra piece of data infrastructure lifts real-world AI use



- Organizations with an infrastructure score of 0 average 1.23 AI use cases.
- At a score of 5, that rises to 3.49 use cases.
- In the controlled logistic model, cloud storage still carries an odds ratio of 1.93 and data agreements 1.58.
- Org age and the broad North-South split stop mattering once those operational signals are in the model.

The 15-staff threshold is not magic, because the first major staffing jump happens earlier

The jump after 15 staff looks more like a hiring threshold than a pure size effect



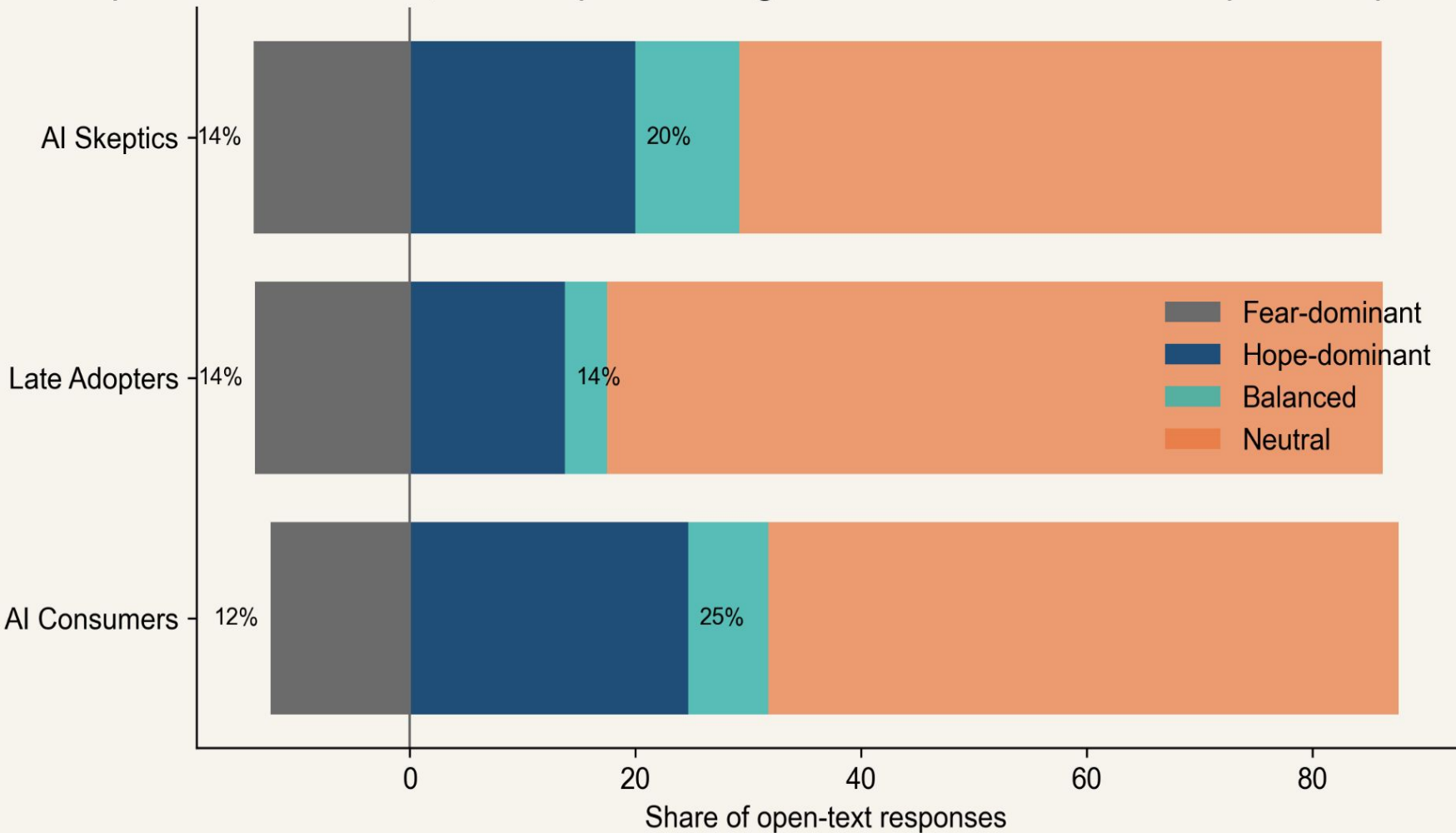
- The biggest staffing jump is from 0-5 staff to 6-15 staff, not from 6-15 to 16-30.
- That tells us the threshold story is really about when the first technical hire becomes possible.
- So '15 staff' is a rough planning heuristic, not a law of nonprofit readiness.

Hope and fear coexist in the open text, and Skeptics sound both more negative and more varied

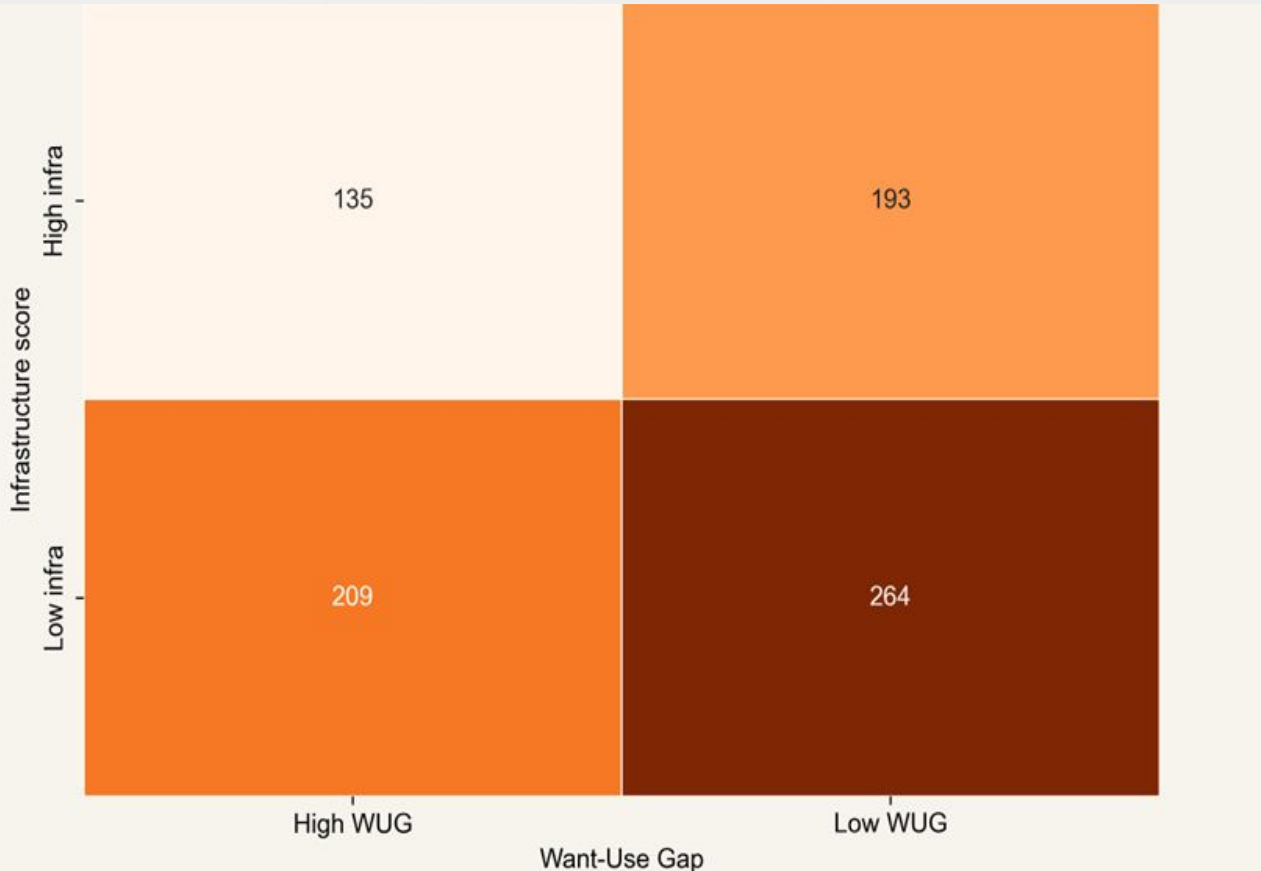
Verified quotes from respondents

- "This can help bridge the educational gap in rural areas by offering high-quality resources that are otherwise inaccessible" (AI Consumers, India, Admin)
- "However, this potential is accompanied by significant challenges and risks that we must navigate carefully" (AI Consumers, India, Governance)
- "Working in journalism, a great fear is abusing AI in the creation of trustworthy information & relaying data" (AI Consumers, North America, Fundraiser)
- "I fear that AI will take the human-ness out of our work, that people will further disconnect from others" (AI Consumers, North America, Leader)

Hope and fear coexist, but Skeptics tilt negative while Consumers keep more upside in view

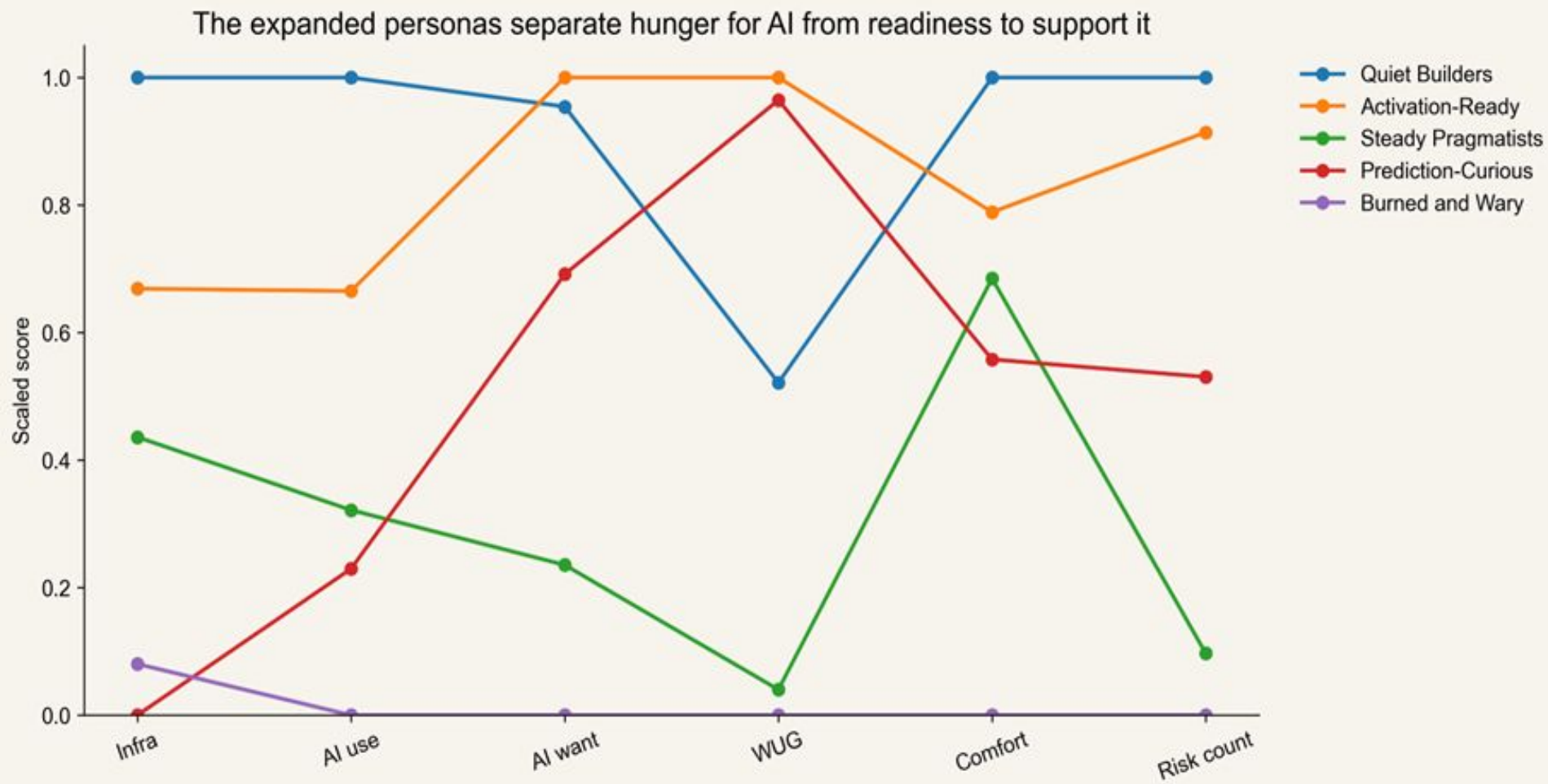


The most actionable quadrant is the nonprofits that want more AI but still need their foundation built first

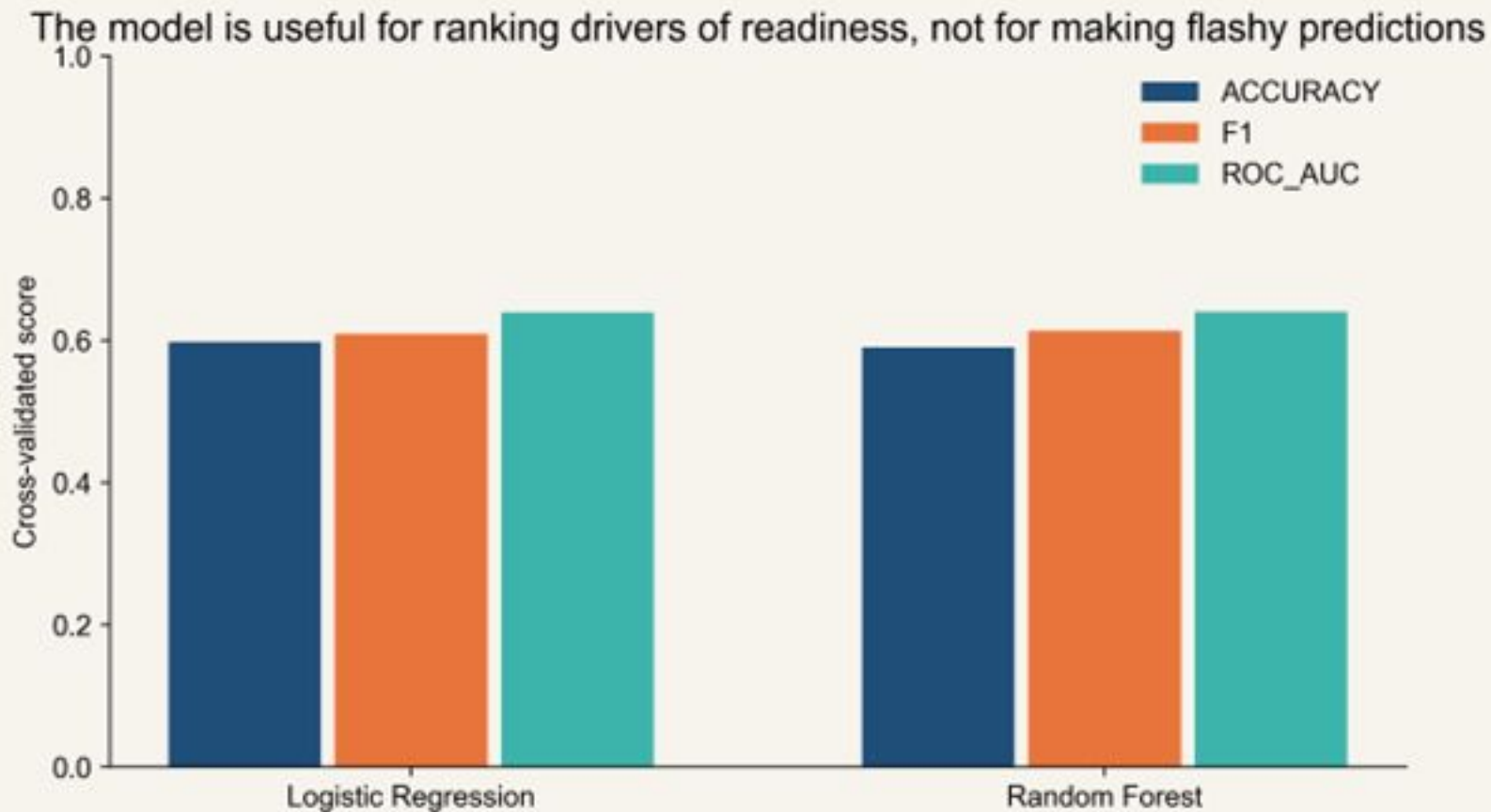


- Foundation-needed includes 209 nonprofits, or 22.47% of the sample.
- Activation-ready groups can absorb pilots now.
- Disengaged groups need AI literacy and low-stakes data practice, not a new product demo.
- Already-well-served groups can become peer mentors and testbeds.

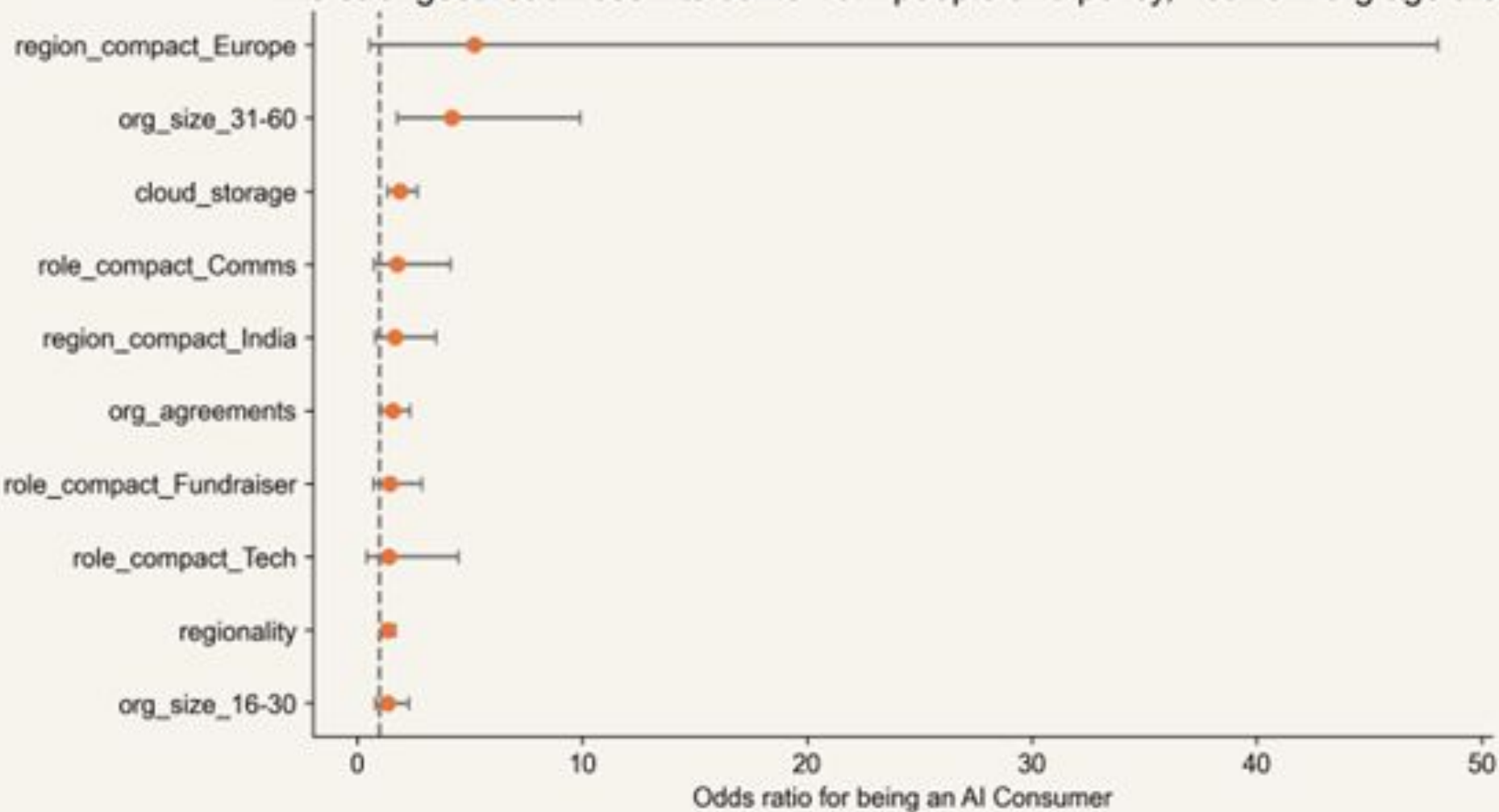
A five-persona lens helps split demand-rich nonprofits from true skeptics



The predictive model is modest, which is exactly why we use it for explanation instead of forecasting



The strongest readiness lifts come from people and policy, not from org age alone



Thank You

Author:

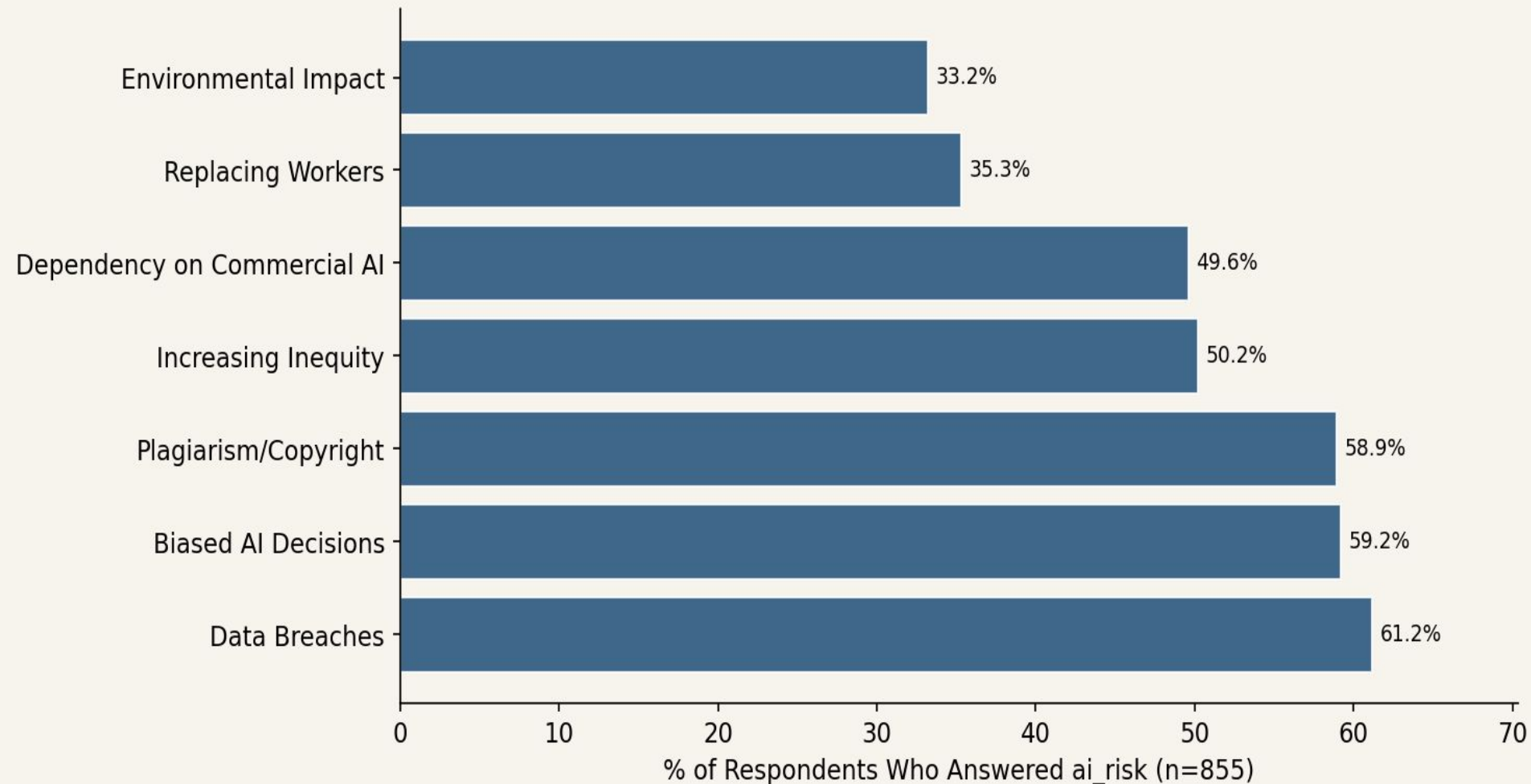
- [Parshv Patel](#): 1st year Data Science student at UC Berkeley
- [Github repo](#)

Sources

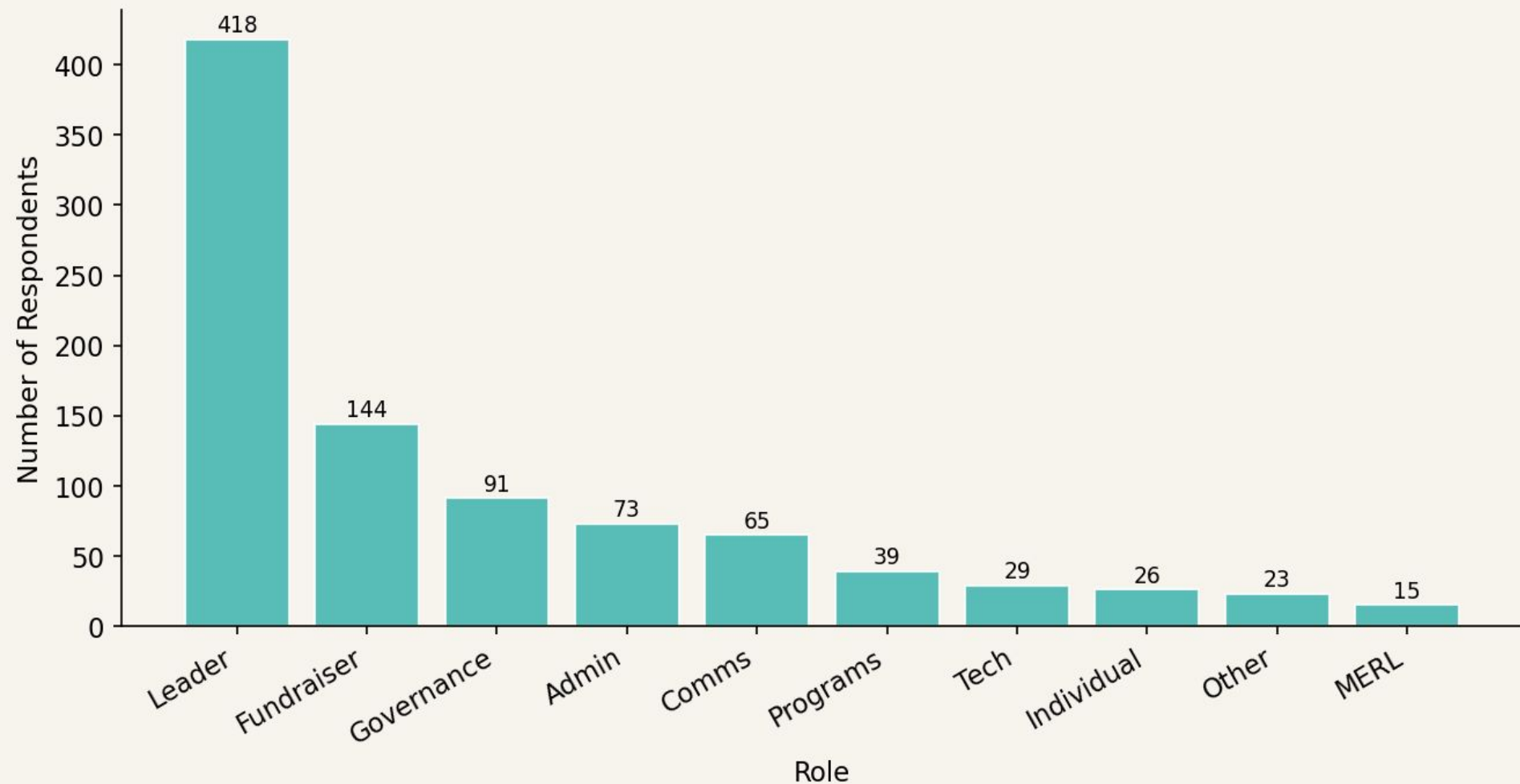
- GivingTuesday, [AI Readiness and Adoption in the Nonprofit Sector in 2024](#)
- GivingTuesday, [AI Readiness Survey Report 2024 India](#)
- data.org, [Data Maturity Assessment](#)
- World Economic Forum, [The AI divide between the Global North and Global South](#)

↓ **Bonus analysis after this** ↓

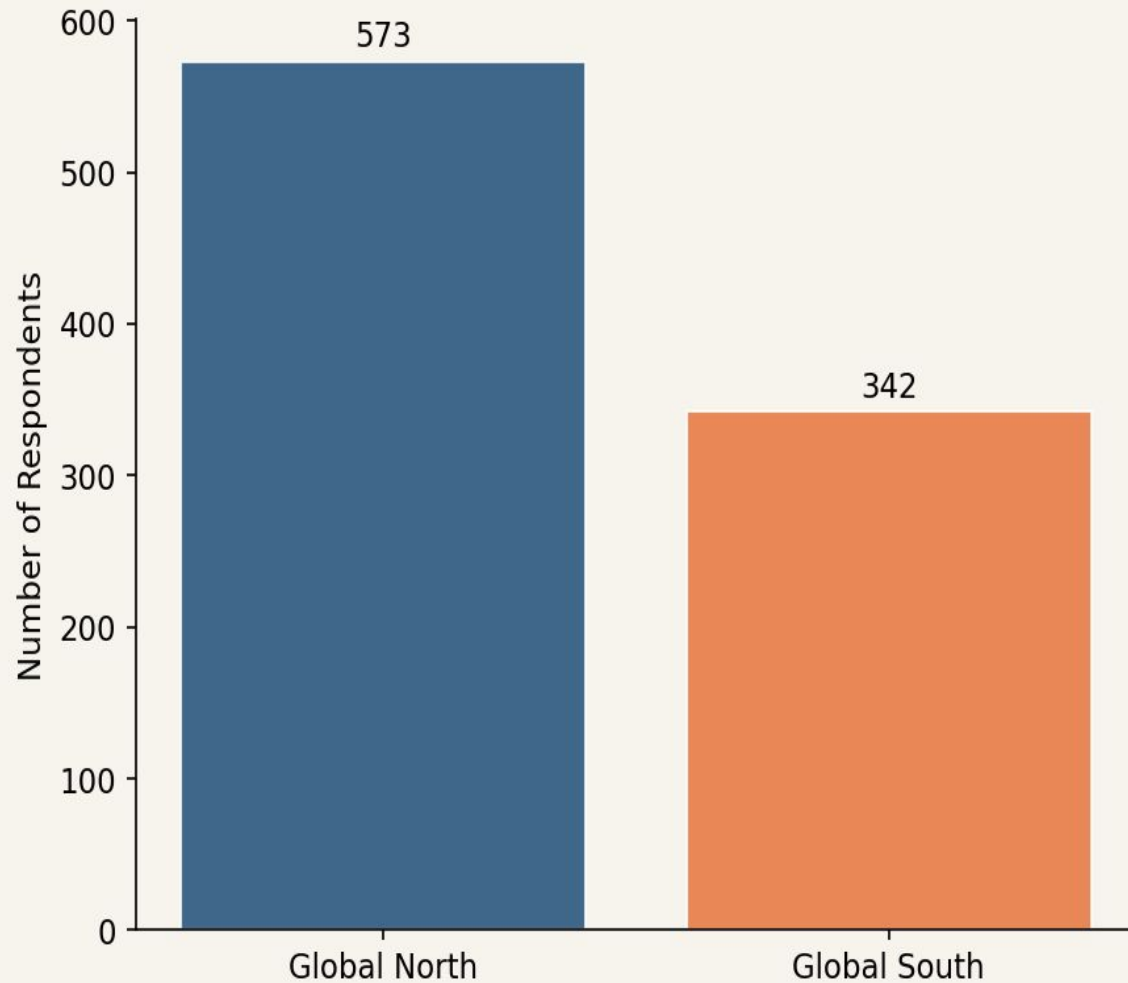
Biased AI Decisions is the Most Cited AI Risk Among Nonprofits



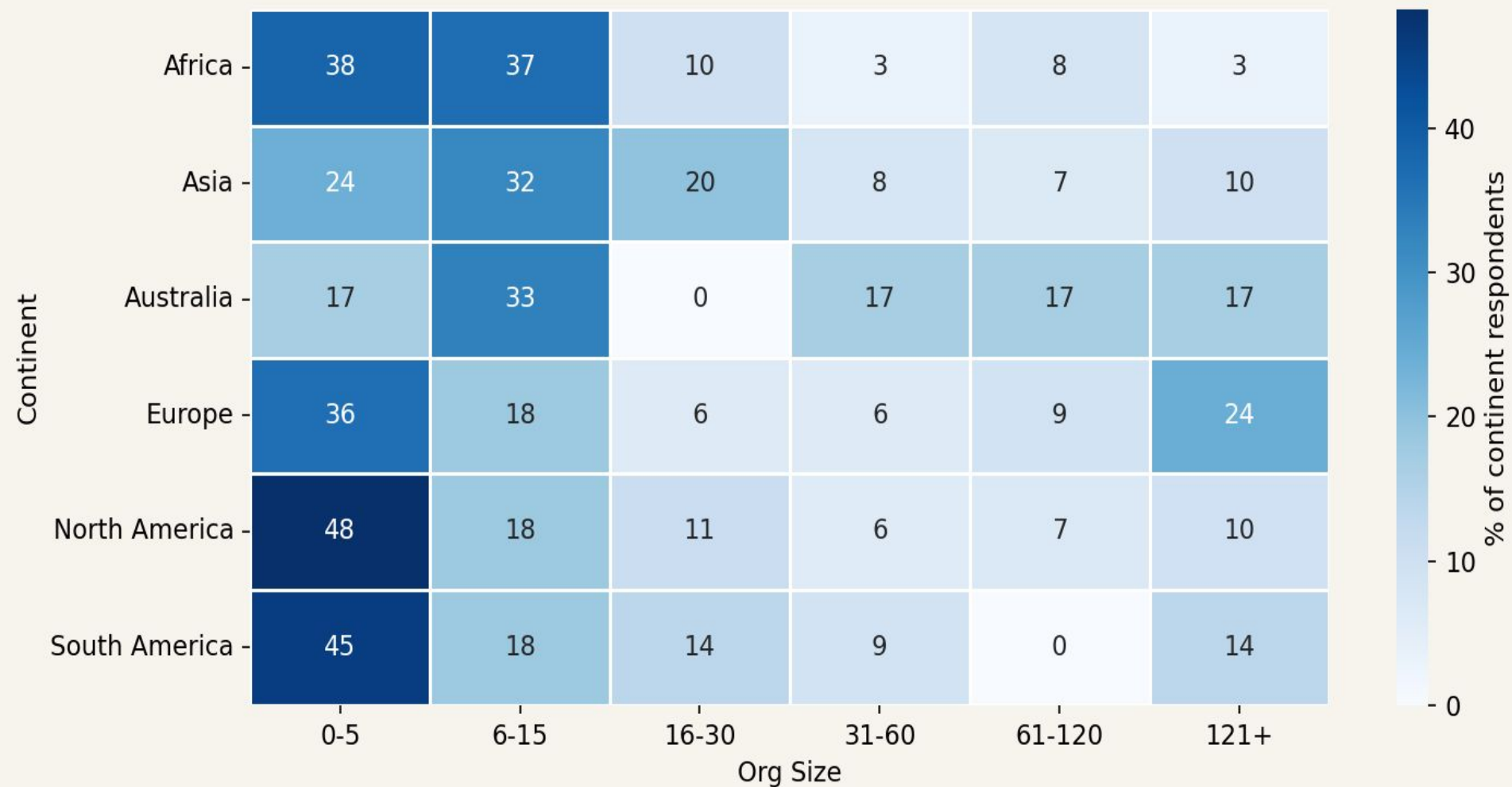
Leaders Represent Nearly Half of All Respondents



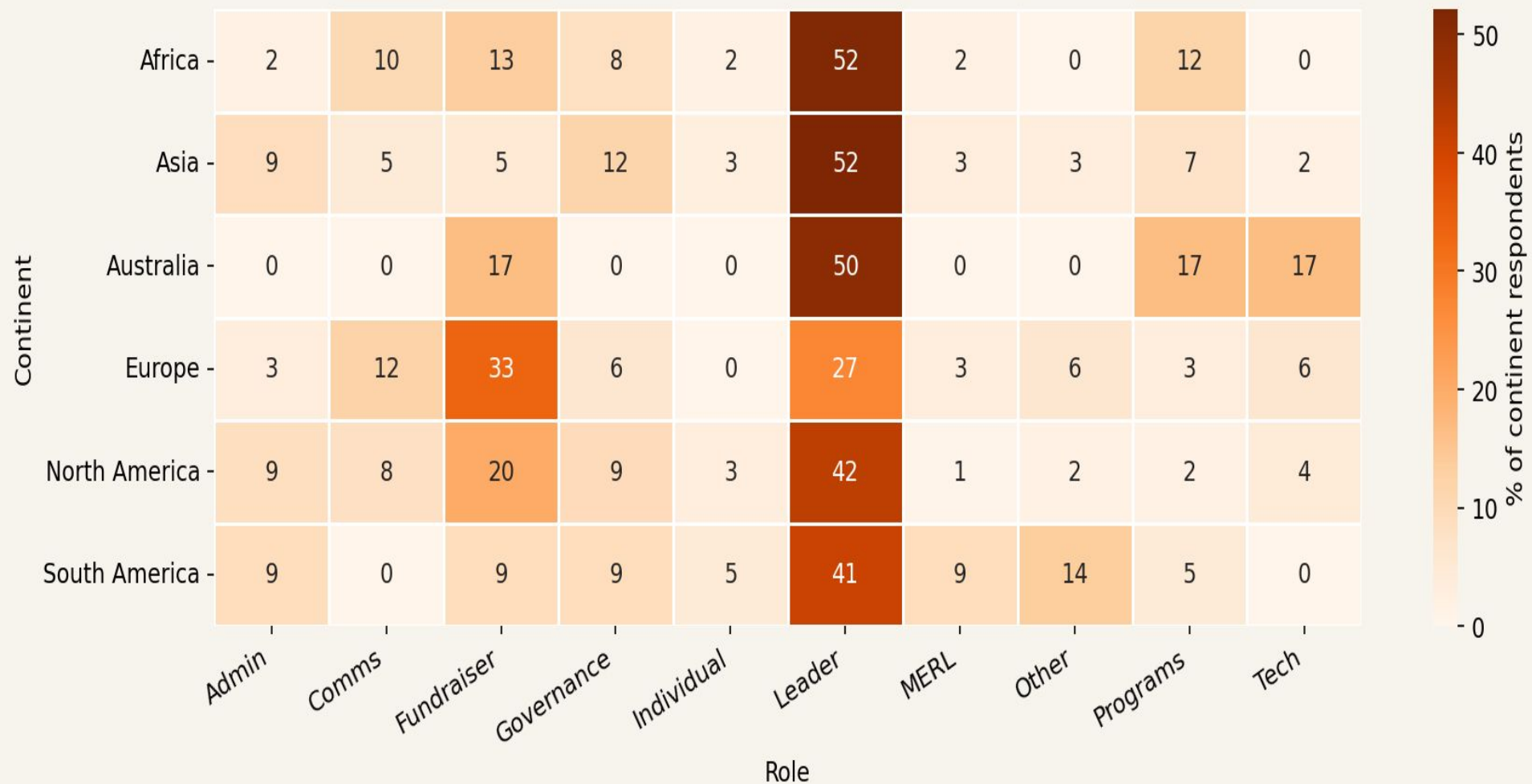
63% Global North, 37% Global South



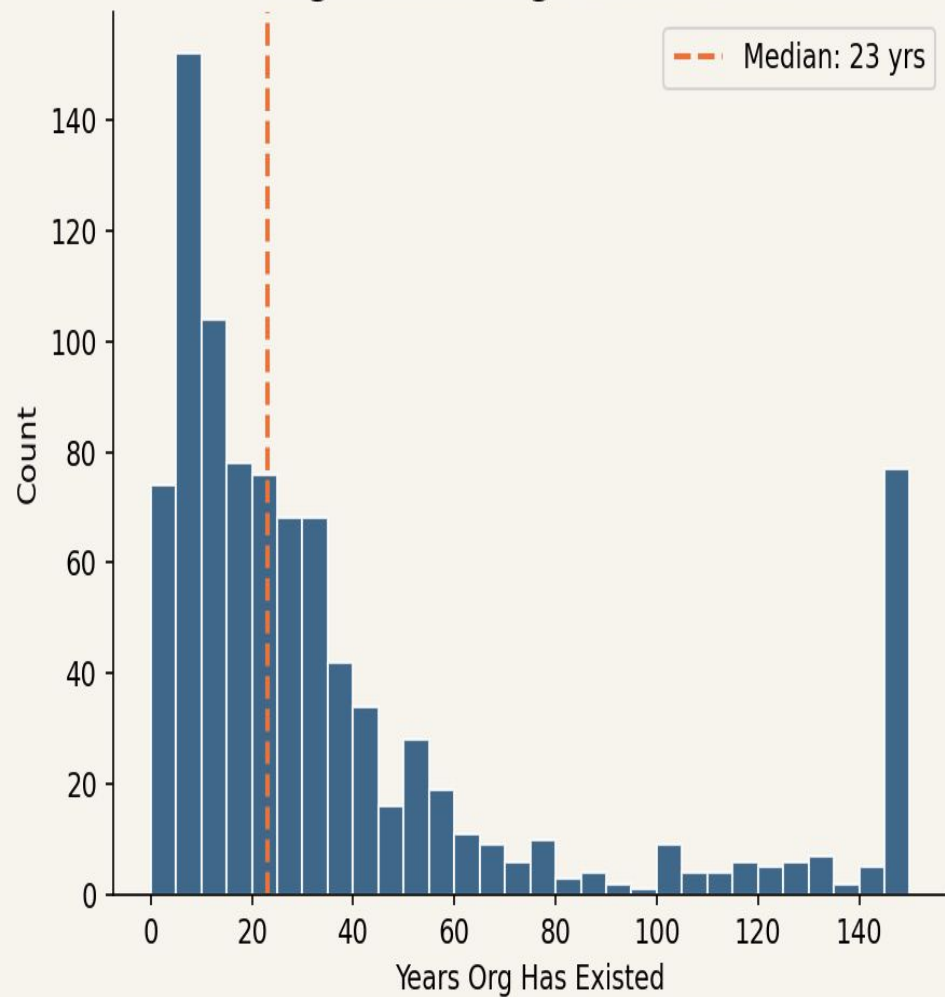
Most Continents Skew Small: % Org Size by Continent



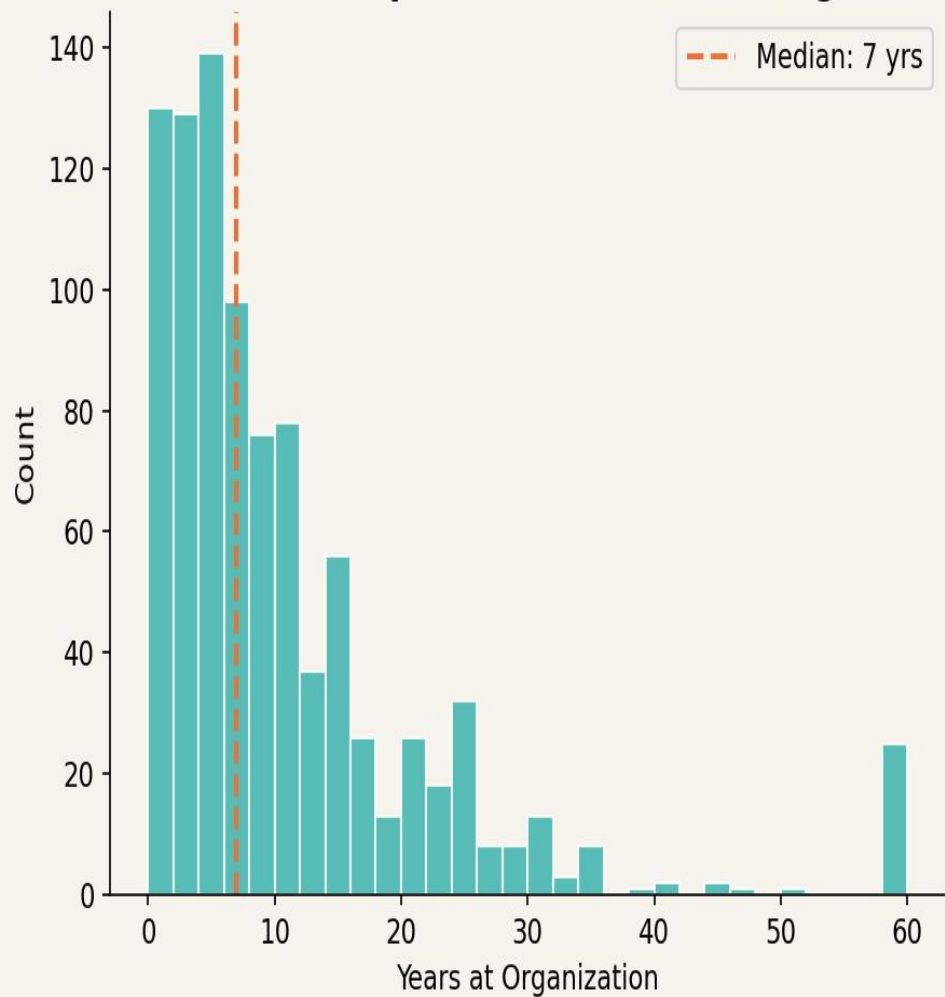
Leader Role Dominates Across All Continents: % Role by Continent

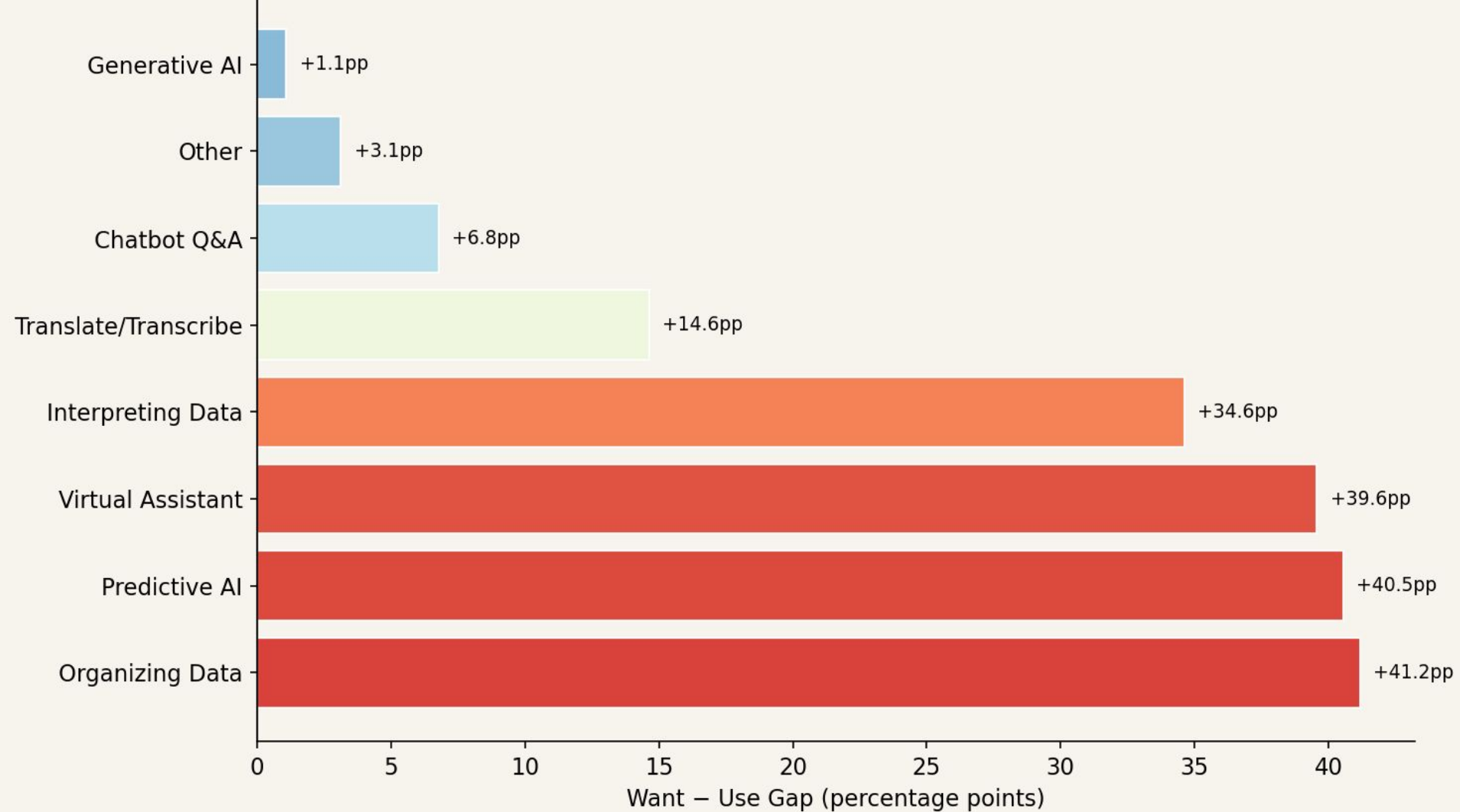


Organization Age Distribution



Years Respondent Has Been at Org

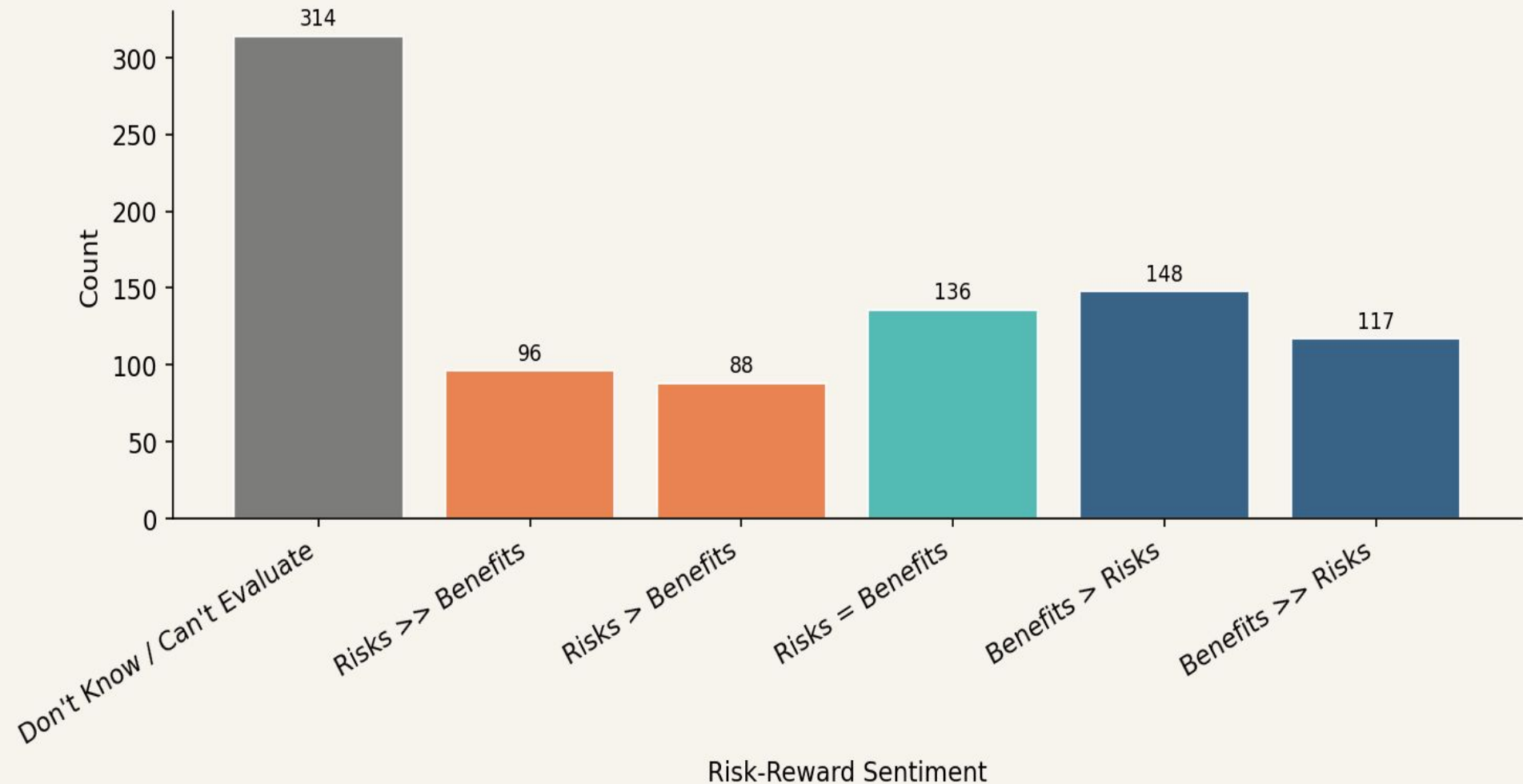




Risk Perceptions Vary Sharply by Role and Risk Type



50% Either Can't Evaluate AI Risk or See Risks = Benefits



Vocabulary shifts from possibility to caution as readiness falls

AI Consumers



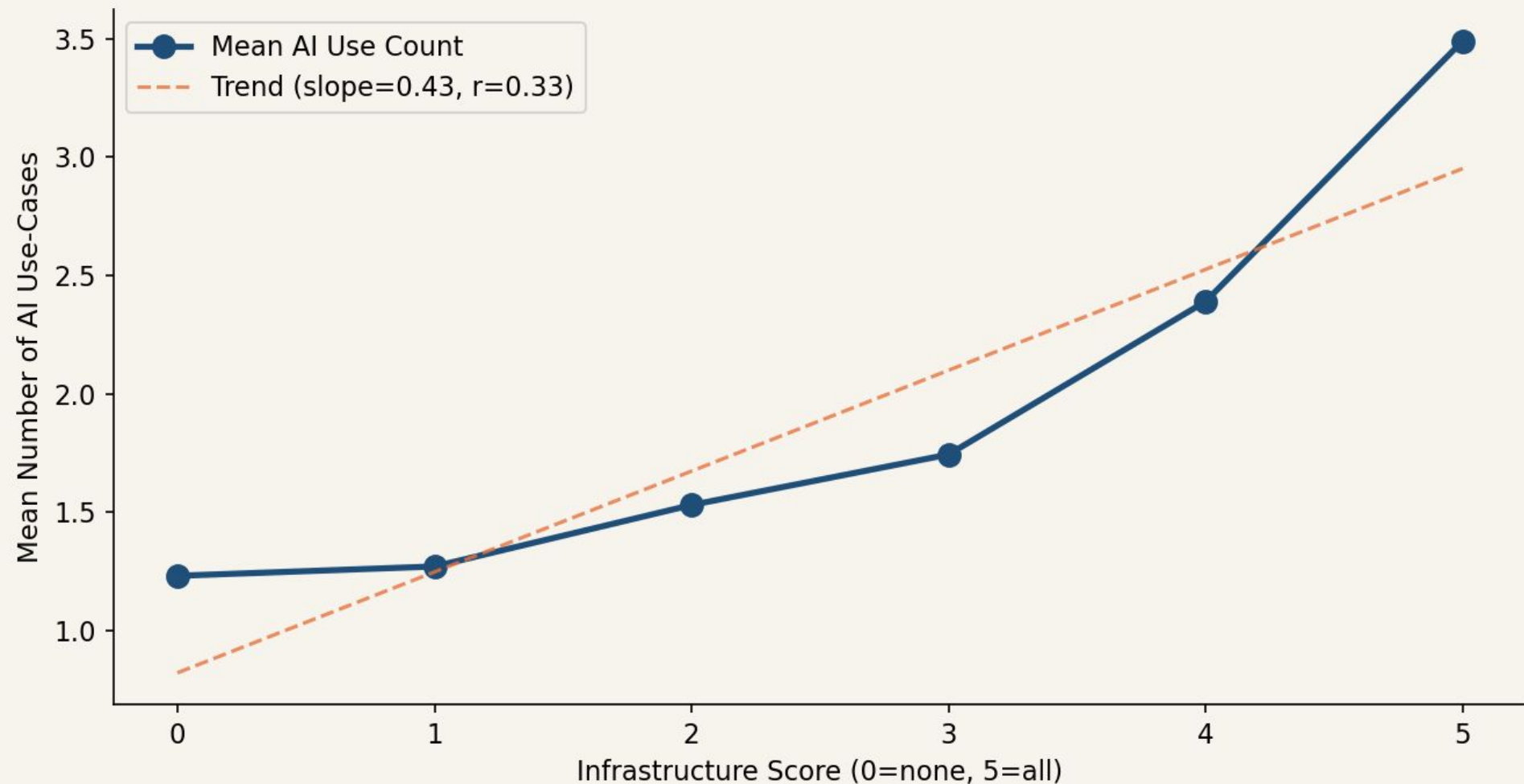
Late Adopters



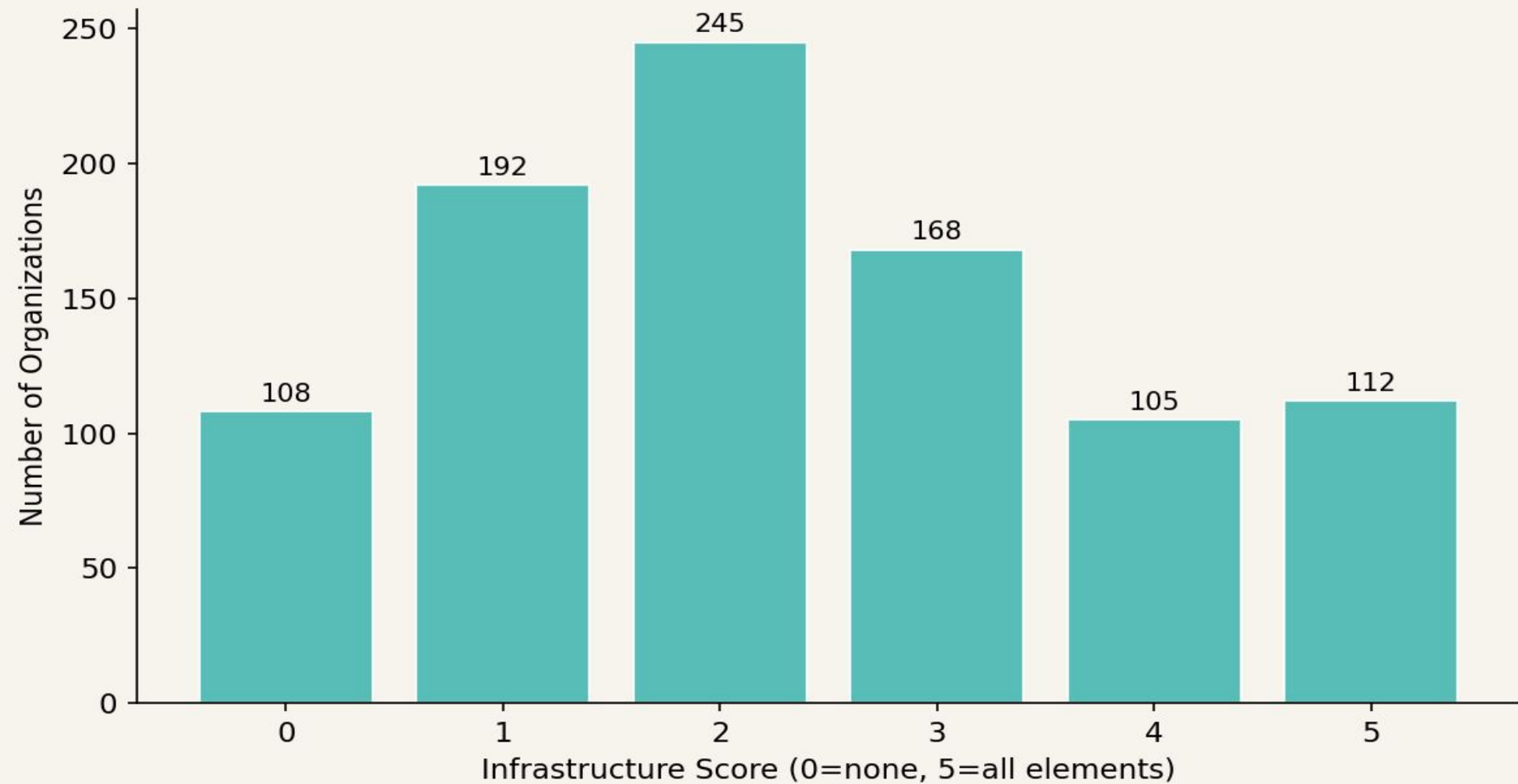
AI Skeptics



More Infrastructure → More AI Use: A Strong Linear Relationship



12% of Nonprofits Have Zero Data Infrastructure Elements



Organizing data, not generative AI, is the biggest unmet need in the survey

